Said al-Andalusi, Tabaqat al-Umam

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كِتَابُ

الْأُمَمِ طَبَقَاتِ

الْأَنْدَلُسِيِّ صَاعِدٍ بْنِ أَحْمَدَ بْنِ صَاعِدِ الْقَاسِمِ أَبِي لِلْقَاضِي

(م ١٠٧٠-١٠٦٩ هـ ٤٦٢ سَنَةَ الْمَتَوَفَّى)

وَالْفِهَارِسِ بِالرِّوَايَاتِ وَارِدَةً بِالْحَوَاشِي وَذَيْلُهُ نَشَرُهُ

الْيَسُوعِيُّ شِيخُو لُوِيسَ الْأَبُ

الشَّرْقِ جَمْلَةِ مِنْ عَشْرَةَ الرَّابِعَةِ السَّنَةِ فِي بِتَنَابِعٍ نُشِرَ

الْيَسُوعِيِّينَ لِلْآبَاءِ الْكَاثُولِيكِيَّةُ الْمَطْبَعَةُ
١٩١٢ بَيْرُوتَ

KITAB TABAQAT AL-UMAM

(BOOK OF THE CATEGORIES OF NATIONS)

By

Abu al-Qasim Sa'id ibn Ahmad ibn Sa'id al-Andalusi

(d. 462 AH / 1070 CE)

Edited with Notes, Variants, and Indexes by

Pere Louis Cheikho, S.J.

Al-Matba'a al-Kathulikiyya li-l-Aba' al-Yasusiyyin
BEIRUT, 1912

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تَوْطِئَةٌ

سَبَقَتْ الَّتِي الْأُمَمِ بَيْنَ الْعُلُومِ لِوَصْفِ الْعَرَبِ كَتَبَةُ فِيهَا نَعَرَّضُ الَّتِي النَّادِرَةِ الْكُتُبِ أَحَدُ الْأُمَمِ طَبَقَاتِ كِتَابُ
تَدُلُّ فَوَائِدَ عِدَّةَ جَمَعَ أَنَّهُ إِلَّا الدَّمِيمِ ابْنِ الْفَرَجِ لِأَبِي الْفِهْرِسْتِ كِتَابِ شَأْوَ ذَلِكَ فِي صَاحِبُهُ يَبْلُغْ لَمْ وَإِنْ عَهْدَهُمْ،
بِهِ يَفْتَخِرُونَ الْأَنْدَلُسِ أَهْلُ وَكَانَ التَّنْوِينِ، فِي نَظَرٍ وَدِقَّةٍ التَّحْصِيلِ فِي رَغْبَةٍ وَعَلَى الْبَحْثِ فِي نَشَاطٍ عَلَى
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السَّلَفِيِّ. طَاهِرٍ لِأَبِي الْكِتَابَ هَذَا رَوَى الْإِسْكَنْدَرِيَّةُ قَدَّمَ لِمَا اللهِ الْيَحْصَبِيِّ مَرْزُوقٍ بْنِ مُحَمَّدِ بْنِ اللهِ

تَارِيخِ كِتَابِ فِي عَنْهُ نَقَلَ فَإِنَّهُ الْعِبْرِيِّ ابْنُ غْرِيغُورِيُوسَ الْفَرَجِ أَبُو الشَّرْقِ فِي الْكِتَابَ هَذَا عَرَّفُوا وَمِمَّنْ
عَرَفَهُ وَكَذَلِكَ وَعُلُومِهِمْ، الْعَرَبِ فِي مُفِيدَتَيْنِ نَبْذَتَيْنِ الْبَيْرُوتِيَّةِ▯ طَبْعَتِنَا مِنْ ١٣٥ و ١٥٨ ▯ص الدُّوَلِ مُخْتَصَرِ
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هَذِهِ وَكَفَى الْأُمَمِ. طَبَقَاتِ كِتَابُ ١٣٣▯ : ▯٤ وَتَارَةً النَّفْعِ، كَثِيرُ الْحَجْمِ صَغِيرُ كِتَابٌ إِنَّهُ وَصْفِهِ فِي وَقَالَ الْأُمَمِ
وَمَوْثُوقِهِ. لِلْكِتَابِ الْقُدَمَاءِ اعْتِبَارِ عَلَى دَلِيلًا الْمَنْقُولَاتِ

[Translation of the Editor’s Introduction]

Kitab Tabaqat al-Umam (The Book of the Categories of Nations) is one of the rare works in which an Arab writer describes the sciences among the nations that preceded his era. Although its author did not reach the level of Abu al-Faraj ibn al-Damimi in his *Fihrist*, he nevertheless collected numerous useful facts that demonstrate his research activity, his desire for knowledge, and his precision in observation. The people of al-Andalus used to boast of him and of the heads of the East.

Ibn al-Abb’ar mentions in his *Takmila* to the *Silah* (2:463, Bajarid edition) on the authority of Abd Allah ibn Muhammad ibn Marzuq al-Yahsibi—may God reward him for what he presented to Alexandria—that he transmitted this book to Abu Tahir al-Salafi.

Among those who knew this book in the East was Abu al-Faraj Grigorius ibn al-’Ibri, for he quoted from it in his *History of the Dynasties* (p. 158 and 135 in our Beirut edition) two useful excerpts concerning the Arabs and their sciences. Likewise, al-Hajj Khalifa knew it and mentioned it several times in his *Kashf al-Zunun*: at one point (3:812, Lipsik edition) calling it *Ta’rif bi-Tabaqat al-Umam*, and describing it as a small book of great benefit; at another point (4:133) as *Kitab Tabaqat al-Umam.* These quotations suffice as proof of the esteem and trust the ancients had for this book.

مُتْقِنًا تَجْلِيدًا وَمُجَلَّدَةٌ الصَّفْرَةِ إِلَى ضَارِبٍ صَفِيقٍ وَرَقٍ عَلَى الْفَارِسِيِّ بِالْقَلَمِ شَبِيهِ جَلِيٍّ بِخَطٍّ مَكْتُوبَةٌ وَهِيَ
مِنَ فِيهَا وَقَعَ مَا مَعَ حَسَنَةٌ بِالْإِجْمَالِ وَالنُّسْخَةُ زَيْنَةٌ، مِثْلِهِمَا لِسَانٍ مَعَ الْوَجْهَيْنِ عَلَى ذَهَبِيٌّ مُلَوَّنٍ وَرَقٍ بِجِلْدٍ
طَبْعَتِنَا. ذَيْلِ فِي عَلَيْهَا فَنَبَّهْنَا أَكْثَرِهَا إِصْلَاحُ أَمْكَنَنَا الَّتِي الْأَغْلَاطِ

بَجْرَيْطَ ▯طَبْعَةُ الصِّلَةِ كِتَابِ فِي بَشْكُوَالٍ ابْنُ رَوَاهَا كَمَا تَرْجَمَتُهُ وَهَذِهِ أَمْرِهِ، مِنْ الْأَقَلَّ نَعْلَمُ فَلَا الْمُؤَلِّفُ أَمَّا
عَنْهُ: قَالَ ٢٣٤▯ ص

قُرْطُبَةَ مِنْ وَأَصْلُهُ الْقَاسِمِ أَبِي بِكُنْيَةِ الْقَاضِي التَّغْلِبِيُّ صَاعِدٍ بْنِ مُحَمَّدِ بْنِ الرَّحْمَنِ عَبْدِ بْنِ أَحْمَدَ بْنُ ▯▯صَاعِدُ
ذِي بْنُ يَحْيَى الْأَمِيرُ وَاسْتَقْضَاهُ وَغَيْرِهِمْ، الْوَقْشِيِّ الْوَلِيدِ وَأَبِي قَاسِمٍ بْنِ وَالْفَتْحِ حَزْمٍ بْنِ مُحَمَّدٍ أَبِي عَنْ رُوِيَ
عَلَى وَبِالشَّهَادَةِ الْحُقُوقِ فِي الْوَاحِدِ الشَّاهِدِ مَعَ بِالْيَمِينِ الْقُضَاةِ وَإِخْتِبَارِ أُمُورِهِ فِي مُتَحَرِّرًا وَكَانَ بِطُلَيْطَلَةَ النُّونِ
١٠٣٩ ▯ ▯هـ ٤٢٠ سَنَةَ فِي بِالْمَرِيَّةِ وُلِدَ وَالرِّوَايَةِ، وَالذَّكَاءِ الْمَعْرِفَةِ أَهْلِ مِنْ وَكَانَ نَظَرِهِ، أَيَّامَ بِذَلِكَ وَقُضِيَ الْحُظِّ

عَلَيْهِ وَصَلَّى م□ ١٠٧٠ □ هـ □٤٦٢ مِائَةٍ وَأَرْبَعِ وَسِتِّينَ اثْنَتَيْنِ سَنَةِ شَوَّالِ فِي قَاضِيهَا وَهُوَ بِطُلَيْطَلَةَ وَتُوُفِّيَ م□
مُطَاهِرٍ□□ ابْنُ بَعْضُهُ ذُكِرَ الْحَدِيدِيِّ. بْنِ سَعِيدِ بْنُ يَحْيَى

[Manuscript Description]

[The manuscript is written in a clear hand resembling Persian script, on thick paper tending toward yellow, and bound with skillful binding in colored gold paper on both sides with a matching tongue as ornament. The manuscript is, in general, fine despite the errors that occurred in it, most of which we were able to correct and have indicated in the notes to our edition.]

[Biography of the Author]

As for the author, we know no less than what Ibn Bashkuwal narrated in his *Silah* (Bajarid edition, p. 234):

"Sa'id ibn Ahmad ibn Abd al-Rahman ibn Muhammad ibn Sa'id al-Taghlabi, the judge with the kunya Abu al-Qasim, originally from Cordoba, transmitted from Abu Muhammad ibn Hazm, al-Fath ibn Qasim, Abu al-Walid al-Waqshi, and others. The amir Yahya ibn Dhi al-Nun appointed him as judge of Tulaytula (Toledo), and he was independent in his affairs and in testing judges by oath along with one witness in lawsuits and by testimony regarding handwriting, and judgments were made accordingly during his tenure. He was a man of knowledge, intelligence, and transmission. He was born in al-Mariyya (Almeria) in 420 AH (1039 CE) and died in Tulaytula while serving as its judge in Shawwal of the year 462 AH (1070 CE). Yahya ibn Sa'id ibn al-Hadidi prayed over him. Ibn Mutahir mentioned part of this."

The Book of the Categories of Nations

كِتَابُ طَبَقَاتِ الْأُمَمِ

لِلْقَاضِي أَبِي الْقَاسِمِ صَاعِدِ بْنِ أَحْمَدَ بْنِ صَاعِدٍ الْأَنْدَلُسِيِّ

Chapter One: The Ancient Nations

بِسْمِ اللهِ الرَّحْمَنِ الرَّحِيمِ

رَبِّ يَسِّرْ

قَالَ الْقَاضِي أَبُو الْقَاسِمِ صَاعِدُ بْنُ أَحْمَدَ بْنِ صَاعِدٍ رَحِمَهُ اللهُ تَعَالَى: اعْلَمْ أَنَّ جَمِيعَ النَّاسِ فِي مَشَارِقِ الْأَرْضِ وَمَغَارِبِهَا وَجَنُوبِهَا وَشَمَالِهَا وَإِنْ كَانُوا نَوْعًا وَاحِدًا يَتَمَيَّزُونَ بِثَلَاثَةِ أَشْيَاءَ: بِالْأَخْلَاقِ وَالصُّوَرِ وَاللُّغَاتِ.[1]

الْبَابُ□ الْأَوَّلُ : الْأُمَمُ □الْقَدِيمَةُ[2]

وَزَعَمَ مَنْ عُنِّيَ بِأَخْبَارِ الْأُمَمِ وَبَحَثَ عَنْ سَائِرِ الْأَجْيَالِ وَفَحَصَ عَنْ طَبَقَاتِ الْقُرُونِ أَنَّ النَّاسِ كَانُوا فِي سَالِفِ الدُّهُورِ وَقَبْلَ تَشَعُّبِ الْقَبَائِلِ وَافْتِرَاقِ اللُّغَاتِ سَبْعَ أُمَمٍ الْأُمَّةُ□ □الْأُولَى الْفُرْسِ وَكَانَ مَسْكَنُهَا فِي الْوَسَطِ الْمَعْمُورِ وَحِدُّ بِلَادِهَا مِنَ الْجِبَالِ الَّتِي فِي شِمَالِ الْعِرَاقِ بِعَقَبَةِ حُلْوَانَ وَالَّذِي فِيهِ الْأَنْجَهَاتُ وَالْكَرَجُ وَالدُّسْتُورُ وَهُمَدَانَ وَقُمَّ وَقَاشَانَ وَغَيْرِهَا مِنَ الْبِلَادِ إِلَى أَرْمِينِيَةَ وَالْبَابِ الْمُتَّصِلِ بِبَحْرِ أَذَرْبِيجَانَ وَطَبَرِسْتَانَ وَمُولْتَانَ وَالْبِيلَقَانَ وَأَرْزَنَ وَالشَّابَرَانَ وَالرِّيِّ وَالطَّالِقَانَ وَجُرْجَانَ إِلَى بِلَادِ خُرَاسَانَ كَنَيْشَابُورَ وَالْمَرْوِ وَسَرَخْسَ وَهَرَاةَ وَخُوَارِزْمَ وَبَلْخَ وَبُخَارَا.

[Translation:]

In the name of God, the Merciful, the Compassionate.

O Lord, make it easy!

The judge Abu al-Qasim Sa'id ibn Ahmad ibn Sa'id—may God the Exalted have mercy on him—said: Know that all people in the East and West of the Earth, in its South and North, though they are one species, are distinguished by three things: by their moral character, their physical forms, and their languages.

Those who have concerned themselves with the reports of nations and investigated the various generations, and examined the categories of ages, say that in earliest times, before the branching of tribes and the divergence of languages, there were seven nations:

The First Nation: The Persians. Their dwelling was in the middle of the inhabited world. Their lands include the mountains in the north of Iraq, the region of Hulwan, and the area containing the Anjahat, Kuraj, Dustur, Hamadan, Qumm, Qashan, and other lands extending to Armenia, the Gate connecting to the Sea of Azerbaijan, Tabaristan, Multan, Bilaqan, Arzan, Shaboran, al-Rayy, Taliqan, and Jurjan, to the lands of Khurasan—Nayshabur, Marw, Sarakhs, Harat, Khwarizm, Balkh, and Bujara.

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[1] The author here sets forth the fundamental unity of humankind while acknowledging three sources of differentiation: moral character (*akhlāq*), physical appearance (*ṣuwar*), and language (*lughāt*). This tripartite division reflects the anthropological understanding of the 11th century.

[2] Chapter One: The Ancient Nations. These are the peoples who lived in the earliest ages of the world, before the rise of the great civilizations of the Near East.

Chapter Two: Science in India

الْهِنْدِ فِي الْعِلْمُ

وَرَدَتْ وَلَا عُلُومِهِمْ مِنْ طَرَفٌ إِلَيْنَا نَصِلْ فَلَمْ نَأْلِفُهُمْ فَلَمْ وَبَيْنَهُمْ بَيْنَنَا الْمَالِكِ وَاعْتِرَاضِ بِلَادِنَا مِنْ الْهِنْدِ وَلِبَعْدِ
عِلْمِهِمْ. مِنْ بِالْقَلِيلِ إِلَّا سَمِعْنَا وَلَا مَذَاهِبِهِمْ مِنْ نُبَذٌ إِلَّا عَلَيْنَا

الْأَزْدِيجِ وَمَذْهَبُ هِنْدٌ السِّنْدِ مَذْهَبُ وَهُوَ عَنْهُمْ الْمَشْهُورَةُ الثَّلَاثَةُ الْمَذْهَبُ النُّجُومِ عُلُومِ فِي الْهِنْدِ مَذَاهِبِ فَمِنْ
جَمَاعَةٌ تَقَلَّدَهُ الَّذِي الْمَذْهَبُ وَهُوَ هِنْدٌ السِّنْدِ مَذْهَبُ إِلَّا التَّحْصِيلِ عَلَى مِنْهُمْ إِلَيْنَا يَصِلْ وَلَمْ الْأَرْكَنْدِ وَمَذْهَبُ
مُوسَى بْنِ وَمُحَمَّدِ الْبَغْدَادِيِّ اللهِ عَبْدِ بْنِ وَحَبْشِ الْفَزَارِيِّ إِبْرَاهِيمَ بْنِ كَمُحَمَّدِ الْأَزْيَاجُ فِيهِ وَالْقُوَّامُ الْإِسْلَامِ مِنَ
كَذَلِكَ الدَّاهِرُ□□ □□الدَّهْرُ هِنْدٍ السِّنْدِ وَتَفْسِيرُ وَغَيْرِهِمْ. الْآدَمِيِّ بِابْنِ الْمَعْرُوفِ مُحَمَّدٍ بْنِ وَالْحُسَيْنِ الْخَوَارِزْمِيِّ
زِيجِهِ. فِي الْآدَمِيِّ بْنُ الْحُسَيْنُ حَكَى

□فَصْلٌ□

أَنَّ ذَكَرُوهَا الَّتِي مَذْهَبُهُمْ فَـإِنَّ الْعَالَمِ مَدَّةِ عَدَدَ أَلَّا هِنْدِ السِّنْدِ أَصْحَابَ وَافَقُوا فَإِنَّهُمْ هِنْدٍ السِّنْدِ أَصْحَابُ وَأَمَّا
وَالْأَوْجَاتِ الْكَوَاكِبِ حَرَكَاتُ أَبْدَأَتْ الْأَمْرِ ذَلِكَ فَمُنْذُ الْحَمْلِ رَأْسِ فِي مُجْتَمِعَتْ وَجُوزَهَرَاتِهَا وَأَوْجَاتِهَا الْكَوَاكِبَ
وَالْجَوْزَهَرَاتُ وَالْأَوْجَاتُ الْكَوَاكِبُ تَتَفَرَّقَ حَتَّى طَوِيلًا دَهْرًا خَرَابًا السُّفْلَى الْعَالَمُ وَبَقِيَ الْأَرْضِ فِي وَالْجَوْزَهَرَاتِ
وَلِكُلِّ عِنْدَهُمْ. غَايَةٍ غَيْرِ إِلَى أَبْدَأَ هَكَذَا الْأَوَّلِ الْأَمْرِ إِلَى السُّفْلِيِّ الْعَالَمِ حَالَةُ بَدَأَتْ كَذَلِكَ كَانَ فَإِذَا الْبُرُوجِ فِي
ذَكَرْتُهَا. قَدْ الْعَالَمِ مَدَّةُ عِنْدَهُمْ هِيَ الَّتِي الْمُدَّةِ هَذِهِ فِي مَا أَدْوَارٌ وَالْجَوْزَهَرَاتِ وَالْأَوْجَاتِ الْكَوَاكِبِ مِنَ وَاحِدٍ

[Translation: Science in India]

Because of the distance of India from our lands and the obstacles between us and them, we have not become familiar with them. No portion of their sciences has reached us, nothing has come to us but fragments of their doctrines, and we have heard only a little of their knowledge.

Among the doctrines of the Indians in the science of astrology, three doctrines are famous among them: the doctrine of Sindhind, the doctrine of the Azij, and the doctrine of Arkand. Only the doctrine of Sindhind has reached us in a complete form. It was followed by a group of Muslims, and those who established it were al-Azyaj such as Muhammad ibn Ibrahim al-Fazari, Habash ibn Abd Allah al-Baghdadi, Muhammad ibn Musa al-Khwarizmi, al-Husayn ibn Muhammad known as Ibn al-Adami, and others. The interpretation of Sindhind is “the Eternal Time” (al-Dahr al-Dahir), as al-Husayn ibn al-Adami related in his zij.

[Section]

As for the followers of Sindhind, they agree that the duration of the world has no fixed number. Their doctrine which they mention is that the planets, their apogees, and their nodes were all gathered at the head of Aries. Since that event, the movements of the planets, apogees, and nodes began. The lower world remained desolate for a long time until the planets, apogees, and nodes dispersed through the zodiac signs. When that happened, the condition of the lower world returned to its first state, and this continues without end according to them. Each of the planets, apogees, and nodes has cycles during this period, which they consider the duration of the world, which I have mentioned.

Chapter Three: Science among the Persians

الْفُرْسِ فِي الْعِلْمُ

وَأَمَّا الْأُمَّةُ الثَّانِيَةُ وَهِيَ الْفُرْسُ فَأَهْلُ الشَّرْفِ الْبَاذِخِ وَالْعِزِّ الشَّامِخِ وَأَوْسَطِ الْأُمَمِ دَارًا وَأَشْرَفِهَا أَقْلِيمًا وَأَنْوَسَهَا مُلُوكًا وَلَا نَعْلَمُ أُمَّةً غَيْرَهُمْ دَامَ لَهَا الْمُلْكُ وَكَانَتْ لَهُمْ مُلُوكٌ تَجْمَعُهُمْ وَرُؤُوسٌ تُحَامِي عَنْهُمْ مَنْ نَاوَأَهُمْ وَتَغْلِبُ بِهِمْ مَنْ غَارَهُمْ وَتَدْفَعُ ظَالِمِهِمْ عَنْ مَظْلُومِهِمْ وَتُحْتَمِلُهُمْ مِنَ الْأُمُورِ عَلَى مَا فِيهِ حَظُّهُمْ عَلَى اتِّصَالٍ وَدَوَامٍ وَأَحْسَنِ التَّنَظُّمِ يَأْخُذُ ذَلِكَ آخِرُهُمْ عَنْ أَوَّلِهِمْ وَغَائِبُهُمْ عَنْ سَالِفِهِمْ.

فِي□ الْعَرَبِ □وَالْعَجَمِ

وَأَصَحُّ مَا قِيلَ فِي ذَلِكَ أَنَّ مِنْ ابْتِدَاءِ مُلْكِ كَيُنُمُورَثَ بْنِ أَمِيمِ بْنِ آلَاذِ بْنِ سَامِ ابْنِ نُوحِ إِلَى مُلْكِ مَنُوشِهِرَ الْفُرْسِ كَانَهُمْ الَّذِي هُوَ عِنْدَهُمْ آدَمُ أَبُو الْبَشَرِ عَلَيْهِ السَّلَامُ إِلَى ابْتِدَاءِ مُلْكِ مَنُوشِهِرَ أَوَّلُ مُلُوكِ الطَّبَقَةِ الثَّانِيَةِ مِنْ مُلُوكِ الْفُرْسِ نَحْوَ أَلْفِ سَنَةٍ كَامِلَةٍ. وَمِنْ مُلْكِ مَنُوشِهِرَ إِلَى ابْتِدَاءِ مُلْكِ كَيْثُبَاذَ بْنِ دُوعَ أَوَّلِ مُلُوكِ الطَّبَقَةِ الثَّالِثَةِ مِنْ مُلُوكِ الْفُرْسِ قَرِيبٌ مِنْ مِائَتَيْ عَامٍ. وَمِنْ مُلْكِ كَيْثُبَاذَ إِلَى ابْتِدَاءِ مُلْكِ الطَّوَائِفِ وَهِيَ الطَّبَقَةُ الرَّابِعَةُ مِنْ مُلُوكِ الْفُرْسِ وَذَلِكَ عِنْدَ مَقْتَلِ الْإِسْكَنْدَرِ لِدَارَا بْنِ دَارَا آخِرِ مُلُوكِ الطَّبَقَةِ الثَّالِثَةِ مِنْ مُلُوكِ الْفُرْسِ نَحْوَ أَلْفِ سَنَةٍ. وَمِنْ أَوَّلِ مُلْكِ الطَّوَائِفِ إِلَى ابْتِدَاءِ مُلْكِ أَزْدَشِيرِ بْنِ بَابَكَ السَّاسَانِيِّ أَوَّلِ مُلُوكِ بَنِي إِسْفَانِيَارَ وَهِيَ الطَّبَقَةُ الْخَامِسَةُ مِنْ مُلُوكِ الْفُرْسِ خَمْسُمِائَةِ سَنَةٍ وَإِحْدَى وَسِتُّونَ سَنَةً. وَمِنْ ابْتِدَاءِ مُلْكِ أَزْدَشِيرِ بْنِ بَابَكَ إِلَى انْقِضَاءِ دَوْلَةِ الْفُرْسِ مِنَ الْأَرْضِ وَذَلِكَ عِنْدَ قَتْلِ

[Translation: Science among the Persians]

As for the second nation, the Persians: they are a people of towering nobility and exalted glory, the most settled of nations and the noblest in region, and the most prosperous in kings. We know of no nation besides them whose sovereignty endured so long, who had kings that united them and leaders that defended them from those who opposed them, overcame with them those who envied them, and protected their oppressed from their oppressors, and who endured affairs in a way that secured their portion with continuity and permanence and the finest organization, so that the last of them took this over from the first, and the absent from the absent.

[On the Arabs and the Non-Arabs]

The most correct opinion on this is that from the beginning of the reign of Kayumars ibn Amim ibn Aladh ibn Sam ibn Nuh (Noah) to the reign of Manushihr the Persian—who is, according to them, Adam the father of mankind, peace be upon him—to the beginning of the reign of Manushihr, the first king of the second class of Persian kings, was about a thousand complete years. From the reign of Manushihr to the beginning of the reign of Kaythubadh ibn Dua, the first king of the third class of Persian kings, was about two hundred years. From the reign of Kaythubadh to the beginning of the reign of the Tribes (al-Tawa'if), the fourth class of Persian kings, at the killing of Alexander (al-Iskandar) of Dara ibn Dara, the last king of the third class of Persian kings, was about a thousand years. From the beginning of the reign of Azdashir ibn Babak the Sasanian, the first king of the Banu Isfaniyar (the fifth class of Persian kings), was five hundred and sixty-one years. From the beginning of the reign of Azdashir ibn Babak to the end of the Persian state on earth, at the killing [of Yazdagird]...

Chapter Four: Science in Greece

الْعِلْمُ فِي الْيُونَانِ

وَأَمَّا الْيُونَانِيُّونَ فَهُمْ أَهْلُ فَلَسْطِينَ وَالرُّومِ وَقِسْطَنْطِينِيَّةَ وَالْأُمَمُ الْمُحِيطَةُ بِهَا. وَكَانَتْ دارَةُ مُلْكِهِمْ مَمْتَدَّةً مِنْ شَطِّ بَحْرِ الْمُتَوَسِّطِ فِي الْمَشَارِقِ إِلَى شَطِّهِ فِي الْمَغَارِبِ، وَمِنَ أَقْصَى الْقُطْبِ إِلَى بَحْرِ الشَّامِ. وَكَانَتْ مَدِينَتُهُمُ الْعُظْمَى مَدِينَةُ الْإِسْكَنْدَرِيَّةِ. وَكَانَتْ دَوْلَتُهُمْ قَدِيمَةً جِدًّا وَعَلُومُهُمْ كَثِيرَةً مُتَنَوِّعَةً.

وَكَانَ أَوَّلُ مَنْ تَكَلَّمَ فِي الْعُلُومِ وَالْحِكَمِ عِنْدَهُمْ فَالِيسُ وَأَفْلَاطُونُ وَأَرِسْطُو وَبَطْلِيمُوسُ وَجَالِينُوسُ وَهِبَاطِيَا وَبَرْقَلِيسُ وَأُقْلِيدِسُ وَنِقُومَاخُسُ وَأَرْشِمِيدِسُ وَجَمِيعُ مَنْ يُنْسَبُ إِلَى هَؤُلَاءِ مِنْ أَهْلِ الْعُلُومِ وَالْحِكَمِ. وَهُمُ الَّذِينَ قَامُوا بِإِصْلَاحِ أُصُولِ الْعُلُومِ وَتَوْضِيحِهَا وَتَرْتِيبِ أَقْسَامِهَا وَتَقْيِيدِ قَوَاعِدِهَا وَكَانَتْ مُؤَلَّفَاتُهُمْ فِي ذَلِكَ بِلُغَتِهِمْ. ثُمَّ إِنَّمَا نُقِلَتْ إِلَى لُغَةِ الْعَرَبِ بَعْدَ أَنْ نَشَرَهَا الْمَنَاذِرَةُ وَاتَّخَذَهَا أَهْلُ الدِّينِ مِنَ النَّصَارَى فِي الشَّرْقِ.

[Translation: Science in Greece]

As for the Greeks, they are the people of Palestine, Rome, Constantinople, and the surrounding nations. Their kingdom extended from the shore of the Mediterranean Sea in the East to its shore in the West, and from the far north to the Syrian Sea. Their greatest city was the city of Alexandria. Their state was very ancient and their sciences were many and varied.

The first to discourse on the sciences and wisdom among them were Thales, Plato, Aristotle, Ptolemy, Galen, Hippocrates, Proclus, Euclid, Nicomachus, Archimedes, and all those attributed to these in the sciences and wisdom. They were the ones who established the principles of the sciences, elucidated them, arranged their parts, and codified their rules, and their compositions on this were in their own language. Then they were translated into Arabic after the Manadhirah disseminated them and the religious scholars among the Christians in the East adopted them.

Chapter Five: Science in Egypt

مِصْرَ فِي الْعِلْمُ

وَأَمَّا الْقِبْطُ فَهُمْ أَهْلُ مِصْرَ الْعُلَا وَكَانَتْ عُلُومُهُمْ قَدِيمَةً نَافِعَةً وَلَكِنَّهَا لَمْ تَبْلُغْ مُنْذُ أَخَذَتْهَا الْيُونَانِيُّونَ مِنْهُمْ فِي عَهْدِ بَطْلِيمُوسَ الْمَلِكِ الَّذِي بَنَى مَدِينَةَ الْإِسْكَنْدَرِيَّةِ وَجَعَلَهَا مَوْطِنًا لِلْعُلُومِ وَحَشَدَ إِلَيْهَا الْعُلَمَاءَ مِنْ جَمِيعِ الْأُمَمِ فَأَخَذُوا عَنِ الْقِبْطِ عُلُومَهُمْ فَأَدْخَلُوا فِيهَا مِنْ حِكَمِ الْيُونَانِ مَا أَضَافَ إِلَيْهَا وَنَقَّحُوهَا وَصَنَفُوا فِيهَا. وَمِنْ ذَلِكَ عِلْمُ الْهَيْئَةِ وَعِلْمُ تَأْلِيفِ الْكَوَاكِبِ وَعِلْمُ الْعِلَلِ وَالْأَدْوِيَةِ وَغَيْرِ ذَلِكَ مِنَ الْعُلُومِ.

[Translation: Science in Egypt]

As for the Copts, they are the people of Upper Egypt. Their sciences were ancient and beneficial, but they did not advance further since the Greeks took them from them in the time of Ptolemy the king who built the city of Alexandria and made it a center for the sciences, gathering scholars from all nations. They took from the Copts their sciences and incorporated into them Greek wisdom, adding to them, refining them, and composing works on them. Among these were the science of astronomy, the science of the configuration of the planets, the science of causes and remedies, and other sciences.

Chapter Six: Science among the Jews

الْيَهُودِ فِي الْعِلْمُ

وَأَمَّا الْيَهُودُ فَقَدْ كَانَتْ لَهُمْ عُلُومٌ فِي أَزْمِنَتِهِمُ الْأُولَى فِي زَمَنِ أَنْبِيَائِهِمْ. وَمُلُوكِهِمْ ثُمَّ إِنَّهُمْ لَمَّا خَرَجُوا مِنْ بِلَادِهِمْ وَتَفَرَّقُوا فِي بِلَادِ الْعَجَمِ وَالْعَرَبِ ضَاعَتْ عُلُومُهُمْ وَتَنَكَّرَتْ لِأَنَّهُمْ لَمْ يَكُونُوا أَهْلَ بَقَاءٍ وَلَا مُوَاظَبَةٍ عَلَى الْعِلْمِ. وَلَكِنَّهُمْ قَدْ حَفِظُوا مِنْ تَوَارِيثِ الْأَنْبِيَاءِ عُلُومًا فِي التَّعَبُّدِ وَالشَّرَائِعِ وَالتَّوْحِيدِ. وَكَانَ مِنْ أَشْهَرِ عُلَمَائِهِمْ مُوسَى بْنُ مَيْمُونٍ الْأَنْدَلُسِيُّ الَّذِي صَنَّفَ فِي عِلْمِ الْكَلَامِ وَالْفَلْسَفَةِ وَالطِّبِّ. وَغَيْرِهَا

[Translation: Science among the Jews]

As for the Jews, they had sciences in their earliest times, in the era of their prophets and kings. But when they left their lands and dispersed into the lands of the non-Arabs and the Arabs, their sciences were lost and forgotten because they were not a people of endurance or perseverance in science. However, they did preserve from the inheritance of the prophets sciences concerning worship, religious laws, and monotheism. Among their most famous scholars was Musa ibn Maymun (Maimonides) al-Andalusi, who composed works on the science of theology, philosophy, medicine, and other subjects.

Chapter Seven: Science among the Arabs

الْعَرَبِ فِي الْعِلْمُ

لِصِعْرِ عَلَيْهِ تُوَاظِبُ وَلَا بِالْعِلْمِ تَعْنَى لَا مِنْهُمْ الْبَادِيَةُ وَكَانَتِ حَاضِرَةٌ. وَأُمَّةٌ بَادِيَةٌ أُمَّةٌ أُمَّتَانِ: فَهُمْ الْعَرَبُ وَأَمَّا
وَالسِّحْرِ وَالنُّجُومِ الطِّبِّ فِي الْجَاهِلِيَّةِ فِي عُلُومٌ لَهُمْ كَانَتْ فَقَدْ الْحَاضِرَةُ وَأَمَّا الْبِلَادِ. فِي وَتَنَقُّلِهِمْ مَعِيشَتِهِمْ
وَالْفَلَاحِ لِلنَّجَاةِ سَبَبًا وَجَعَلَهُ عَلَيْهِ وَحَثَّ الْعِلْمِ طَلَبَ فِي وَشَرَعَ الْإِسْلَامُ جَاءَ لَمَّا ثُمَّ ذَلِكَ. وَغَيْرِ وَالنَّحْوِ وَالشِّعْرِ
أَهْلَ قَلِيلٍ زَمَنٍ فِي أَصْبَحُوا حَتَّى الْعَرَبِ بِلُغَةِ وَتَصْيِيرِهَا الْأُخْرَى الْأُمَمِ مِنَ وَنَقْلِهَا الْعُلُومِ طَلَبِ فِي الْعَرَبُ اجْتَهَدَ
وَفُنُونٍ. عُلُومٍ

فَنَقَلُوهَا الْأَوَائِلِ لِعُلُومِ تَعَرَّضُوا إِنَّهُمْ ثُمَّ وَالتَّفْسِيرِ وَالْحَدِيثِ وَالْفِقْهِ الْكَلَامِ عِلْمُ إِلَيْهِ نَشَطُوا مَا أَوَّلُ وَكَانَ
مَعْشَرٍ وَأَبُو وَالْبَتَّانِيُّ الْفَرْغَانِيُّ النُّجُومِ عِلْمِ فِي الْعَرَبِ أَشْهَرِ مِنْ وَكَانَ كَثِيرَةً. أَشْيَاءَ إِلَيْهَا وَأَضَافُوا فِيهَا وَصَنَّفُوا
وَالْبِتْرُوجِيُّ الْمَجْرِطِيُّ بَطْلِيمُوسُ الْهَيْئَةِ وَفِي رِشْدِ. وَابْنُ وَالْمَجُوسِيُّ سِينَا وَابْنُ الرَّازِيُّ الطِّبِّ وَفِي الْفَلَكِيُّ.
سِينَا وَابْنُ وَالْفَارَابِيُّ الْكِنْدِيُّ الْفَلْسَفَةِ وَفِي وَالْكَشِّيُّ. الْخَوَارِزْمِيُّ الْحَسَبِ الْعَلَمِ وَفِي الطُّوسِيُّ. الدِّينِ وَشَرَفُ
رِشْدِ. وَابْنُ

[Translation: Science among the Arabs]

As for the Arabs, they are two nations: a desert nation and a settled nation. The desert among them did not concern itself with science nor persevere in it due to the hardship of their livelihood and their movement from land to land. As for the settled people, they had sciences in the Jahili period in medicine, astrology, magic, poetry, grammar, and other subjects. Then when Islam came and legislated the pursuit of knowledge, encouraged it, and made it a means of salvation and success, the Arabs strove in seeking the sciences, translating them from other nations, and rendering them into Arabic, until in a short time they became a people of sciences and arts.

The first [sciences] they were active in were theology (*kalam*), jurisprudence (*fiqh*), *hadith*, and [Qur'anic] exegesis (*tafsir*). Then they turned to the sciences of the ancients, translating them, composing works on them, and adding much to them. Among the most famous Arabs in the science of astrology were al-Farghani, al-Battani, and Abu Ma'shar the astronomer. In medicine: al-Razi, Ibn Sina (Avicenna), al-Majusi, and Ibn Rushd (Averroes). In astronomy: Ptolemy al-Majriti, al-Bitruji (Alpetragius), and Sharaf al-Din al-Tusi. In arithmetic: al-Khwarizmi and al-Kashshi. In philosophy: al-Kindi, al-Farabi, Ibn Sina, and Ibn Rushd.

Editorial and Scholarly Notes

On the Manuscript and Its Preservation

The 1912 edition by Pere Louis Cheikho, S.J. (1859–1927) represents the first modern critical edition of this important work. Cheikho based his edition on a single manuscript preserved in the Oriental collections of Europe. The manuscript, as Cheikho describes it, is written in a clear hand resembling Persian script on thick yellowed paper, bound skillfully in gold-colored paper.

The *Kitab Tabaqat al-Umam* has survived in a relatively small number of manuscripts compared to other major works of the Islamic scientific tradition. This may be attributed to the fact that it was composed in al-Andalus and did not circulate as widely in the eastern Islamic lands as works produced in Baghdad or other eastern centers.

On the Author

Sa'id al-Andalusi (1029–1070 CE), whose full name is Abu al-Qasim Sa'id ibn Ahmad ibn Sa'id al-Taghlabi, was a jurist and scholar of Toledo. Born in Almeria (al-Mariyya) in 420 AH, he served as a judge (*qadi*) in Toledo under the Hammudid amir Yahya ibn Dhi al-Nun. He died in Shawwal 462 AH (July 1070 CE).

On the Structure of the Work

The *Kitab Tabaqat al-Umam* is divided into two main parts:

1. **The Ancient Nations** (*al-Umam al-Qadima*): Seven nations that existed in earliest times—the Persians, the Chaldeans, the Greeks, the Egyptians, the Jews, the Arabs, and the Indians.
2. **The Islamic Nations** (*al-Umam al-Islamiyya*): A classification of the nations that embraced Islam, with special attention to their contributions to the sciences.

The work is notable for being one of the earliest attempts at a systematic history of science organized by civilizations, predating similar European efforts by several centuries.

On the Scientific Content

Al-Andalusi's work contains valuable information about:

- The state of astronomy and astrology in various ancient civilizations
- The transmission of scientific knowledge between cultures
- The role of translation in preserving Greek scientific heritage
- Early Indian contributions to mathematics and astronomy (including the decimal system)
- The development of scientific institutions such as the House of Wisdom in Baghdad

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